

ONLINE INFORMATION HANDLING PROTOCOL

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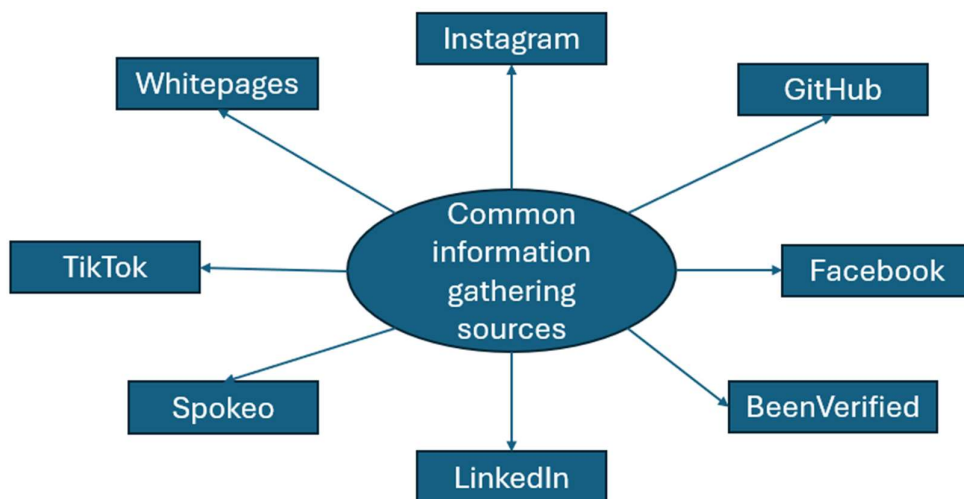
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Introduction

This online information handling protocol is designed in aiding users to have more control over their data and maintain tighter OPSEC. This protocol was developed because currently attackers can compromise data brokers, use social media or people searching sites to perform spear-phishing attacks. Some common sources attackers use to find information are TikTok, Instagram, Spokeo, LinkedIn and Facebook. These are commonly used to the amount of data available either from users themselves or data collected over time by data brokers like Spokeo.

This protocol cannot provide perfect OPSEC or get rid of all personal information stored by data brokers. However, this protocol can tighten OPSEC and allow you to have more control over your data. This protocol can be used by anyone but its mainly for those with threat models such as competitors, organised cybercriminals, hacktivists, nation-state. Make sure to adapt this protocol based on your own security needs and threat model. You may look at my security architecture, other frameworks or do your own research if this protocol can't be adapted to your needs.



The spider diagram above shows the common sources that an attacker gathers information from. This diagram doesn't show all sources of information they may use. As for example, nation-state actors may have access to government records and logs directly from providers. Make sure to do specific research based on your threat model.

Main Online information Handling Protocol Section

- This protocol is designed to help you control your personal data and maintaining OPSEC on social media and other online applications.
- For those with nation-state actors, you will need to layer more OPSEC protections to stay hidden.
- These protections can for example be separate identities, using VPN and tor, encrypted email services.
- The first step is to calm down as always
- This can be done by taking some deep breathes or releasing anger in a non-harmful way
- This step is important to reduce any emotional noise and allow you to focus more
- The second step is creating or using a database
- This means having a securely stored database that tracks which providers currently have access to your data
- This could be done using the structure what (The provider) → Type (What kind of data do they have?) → Security (How secure is your data in this provider?) → Impact (What could happen if that provider were to be breached?).
- This step does not mean that you need to track every single entity that has your data. That is impossible and only the most sensitive providers should be logged
- If you already have created a database, you can use this as cross-reference in the searching step
- The third step is searching
- This step means searching for personal information about yourself online
- This information can include full name, age, address and DOB.
- Searching for this information can be done through search engines, AI models, reviewing your own social media and free tiers of people searching sites.
- Do be warned that using certain AI models and search engines can be a privacy risk. Make sure to use privacy tools as needed.
- The fourth step is the removal
- This step means removing that personal information about yourself online
- This can be done by removing personal information shown on social media accounts and opting out of people searching sites.
- The removal process should be documented inside of the database you made in the second step of this protocol.
- You should also make sure to verify that the removal was successful by reusing the searching step.
- This protocol should be repeated depending on your threat model and schedule as users have multiple other things in their life to deal with.
- Make sure to adapt this protocol as needed to your own security needs.

Online Information Handling Protocol Trade-Offs

- **This online information handling protocol has trade-offs just like any other system I have created so far.**
- **Users may experience further implementation challenges depending on their online presence.**
- **I have identified 4 main trade-offs.**
- **The first trade-off is time consumption.**
- **This trade-off exists because searching, documenting and removal processes can be extremely time consuming.**
- **This means that users may not be able to have time to fit into their schedule.**
- **This trade-off can be managed by incremental progress, layering actions based on threat model and accepting that they won't be able to remove all information about themselves online.**
- **The second trade-off is cognitive load.**
- **This trade-off exists because removing data from sites especially data brokers can be quite stressful and frustrating.**
- **This means that users may give up or make mistakes during the protocol's processes.**
- **This trade-off can be managed by starting with the easiest removals and using automated tools.**
- **The third trade-off is cost.**
- **This trade-off exists because using automated tools and using certain searching tools can cost subscriptions to use.**
- **This means that cognitive load is higher and the removal or searching process takes longer than with automated tools.**
- **This trade-off can be managed by free private searching tools, self-created tools and structured time management.**
- **The fourth trade-off is complexity.**
- **This trade-off exists because some data brokers make it a technical nightmare process to remove your data off their site.**
- **This means that users may give up or are not able to successfully remove their data from the data broker.**
- **This trade-off can be managed by automated tools, structured processes for removal and accepting that you won't be able to remove your data from every data broker.**